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E3 Reading – Exam Prep Lesson 9: Synonyms, opposites and word families – Lesson plan and answers

Learners finish able to match a word in the text with a simpler word of the same meaning, use an opposite as a clue, and recognise different forms of the same word. This builds AC1.4 and helps with every question, because questions rarely repeat the words of the text.

Materials: Handouts 9A, 9B and 9C, one per learner. The sixteen word cards from 9A cut up, one set per pair.

Activity 1: Same meaning, different word (25 minutes, teacher-led)

1. Write on the board: *The shop is big. The store is large.* Ask if the two sentences mean the same. Underline the pairs. Teach the word *synonym* and say it is the exam's favourite trick: the text says one word and the question says another.
2. Call out eight easy words. Learners shout a synonym: *start, small, happy, begin, quick, difficult, speak, old*. Accept anything close.
3. Give each pair the sixteen cards from 9A. They match them into eight synonym pairs on the desk.
4. Check on the board. Drill pronunciation of *elderly, exhausted, pleased, doubtful*.
5. Pairs play memory: cards face down, turn two over, keep them if they are synonyms. Five minutes.
6. Learners write the eight pairs in the table on 9A to keep.

Activity 2: Opposites as clues (20 minutes, teacher-led)

1. Write: *The street is usually noisy, but on Sunday it is peaceful.* Ask what *peaceful* means. Ask how they know. Establish that *but* tells the reader an opposite is coming, so *peaceful* is the opposite of *noisy*.
2. Board more signal words for opposites: *but, however, not… but…, at first… now…*
3. Give three more sentences orally and ask for the meaning of the last word each time: "My old flat was huge, but this one is tiny." "At first she was nervous. Now she is relaxed." "The soup was not hot but lukewarm."
4. Hand out 9B. Learners read the text once for the general idea. Ask: What is a quiet hour? Who likes it? Does everyone like it?
5. Learners find two places where an opposite helps with a new word. Take answers: *bright* in paragraph 1 and *dim* in paragraph 2; *At first he was doubtful… In fact…* in paragraph 4.

Activity 3: Word meaning questions (30 minutes)

1. Hand out 9C. Learners answer section A alone in 15 minutes, with no dictionaries or phones.
2. Pairs compare. For each answer they tell each other the clue they used.
3. Class feedback. For each question ask: "Which words near it helped?" For question 1, the clue is the list *loud, bright and crowded*. For question 5, the clue is the next sentence, where shoppers complain.
4. For the true or false items, remind learners of Lesson 4: find the word, read around it, then decide.
5. Section A, question 8 asks learners to find a word in the text from its meaning. Show the method: go to the paragraph, try each likely word in place of the meaning, and see which one fits.

Activity 4: Word families (25 minutes, teacher-led then pairs)

1. Write *manage* on the board. Ask who manages a shop. Write *manager*. Ask for other *-er* people: *shopper, teacher, driver, cleaner*.
2. Write *noise* and *noisy*. Ask which is a thing and which describes. Add *quiet* and *quietly*, *complain* and *complaint*.
3. Explain why this matters: the text may say *complain* and the question may say *complaint*. It is the same idea.

4. Learners complete section B of 9C alone, changing the word in brackets to fit the sentence.
5. Check in pairs and on the board. Spell the answers aloud together.

Activity 5: Say it another way (20 minutes)

1. Read out a sentence from the text. Pairs rewrite it with at least one word changed for a synonym, keeping the meaning. Example: “Elderly customers said they felt calmer” becomes “Old shoppers said they felt more relaxed.”
2. Do five sentences. After each, hear two versions and let the class judge if the meaning is the same.
3. Explain that this is exactly what the people who write exam questions do.
4. Close: each learner chooses three new words from today and writes them with a synonym in their notebook.

Answer key, Lesson 9

- **9A pairs:** start and begin; shop and store; old and elderly; very tired and exhausted; happy and pleased; short and brief; not sure and doubtful; loud and noisy.
- **9C Section A:** 1 A. 2 False. 3 B. 4 A. 5 B. 6 False. 7 C. 8 store; began; complain.
- **9C Section B:** 1 manager. 2 noisy. 3 shoppers. 4 complaint. 5 quietly.

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